

UPSC GS Mains Paper 4 (GS-IV) - Ethics

Complete Quotes & Philosophical

Compilation (2013-2025)

This document compiles all the philosophical, moral, and administrative quotations used by the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) in the GS-IV (Ethics, Integrity & Aptitude) Mains examinations. These are structured into two sections: **Core Thinker & Philosopher Quotations** (interpreting quotes by major ethical leaders) and **Key Administrative Maxims & Conceptual Statements**.

[TIP]

How to Answer Quotation-Based Questions (10 Marks, 150 Words):

- Deconstruct the Quote (30-40 words):** Explain the quote's core meaning in simple terms. Mention the thinker and their philosophical school (e.g., Kantian Deontology, Gandhian Trusteeship, Virtue Ethics).
- Administrative Application (80-90 words):** Connect the value to public service. How does this help a civil servant handle ethical dilemmas, conflicts of interest, or decision-making?
- Substantiate with Examples:** Provide concrete examples of legendary public servants (e.g., Lal Bahadur Shastri, E. Sreedharan), historical figures, or contemporary situations.
- Conclusion (20-30 words):** End with a forward-looking thought on how this principle ensures ethical governance and public welfare.

Thinker Frequency Analysis (2013-2025)

The table below shows how frequently quotations of specific thinkers have appeared in GS-IV Mains Section A:

Rank	Thinker / Philosopher	Number of Questions	Key Themes Asked
1	Mahatma Gandhi	6	Kindness, Selfless Service, Thoughts & Action, Anger & Intolerance, Forgiveness, Need vs Greed
2	Swami Vivekananda	5	Morality vs Law, Assimilation of Ideas, Self-love & Karma, Perseverance, Non-condemnation

Rank	Thinker / Philosopher	Number of Questions	Key Themes Asked
3	Dalai Lama	3	Conscience and Wisdom, Value of Success, Inner Peace
4	APJ Abdul Kalam	3	Role of Parents/Teachers, Righteousness, Global Peace, Corruption-free society
5	Thiruvalluvar	2	Resilience in Trouble, Utilitarian Truth
6	Immanuel Kant	2	Human beings as Ends, Law vs Ethics (Intent)
7	Socrates	2	Illusion of Emotional Morality, The Unexamined Life
8	Abraham Lincoln	2	Administrative Pragmatism, Power and Character
9	Warren Buffett	1	Various philosophical interpretations
10	Samuel Johnson	1	Various philosophical interpretations
11	William James	1	Various philosophical interpretations
12	Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel	1	Various philosophical interpretations
13	Jawaharlal Nehru	1	Various philosophical interpretations
14	Potter Stewart	1	Various philosophical interpretations
15	Erik Erikson	1	Various philosophical interpretations
16	Aristotle	1	Various philosophical interpretations
17	John Ruskin	1	Various philosophical interpretations
18	Napoleon Bonaparte	1	Various philosophical interpretations

Summary Table: Core Thinker & Philosopher Quotes (Topic-Wise)

Total quotation-based questions compiled: **42**.

Year	Thinker / Source	Full Quote	Syllabus Topic
2018;10M	Warren Buffett	<i>"In looking for people to hire, you look for three qualities: integrity, intelligence and energy. And if they do not have the first, the other two will ruin you."</i>	Aptitude and Foundational Values
2014;10M	Samuel Johnson	<i>"Integrity without knowledge is weak and useless, but knowledge without integrity is dangerous and dreadful."</i>	Aptitude and Foundational Values
2024;10M	UPSC Contextual	<i>"Mindless addiction to Form, ignoring the Substance of the matter, results in rendering of injustice. A perceptive civil servant is one who ignores such literalness and carries out true intent."</i>	Attitude
2020;10M	Dalai Lama	<i>"Hatred is destructive of a person's wisdom and conscience that can poison a nation's spirit."</i>	Attitude
2025;10M	Swami Vivekananda	<i>"The strength of a society is not in its laws, but in the morality of its people."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2025;10M	Thiruvalluvar	<i>"Those who in trouble untroubled are, Will trouble trouble itself."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2025;10M	William James	<i>"The greatest discovery of my generation is that a human being can alter his life by altering his attitudes."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2024;10M	Immanuel Kant	<i>"In law, a man is guilty when he violates the rights of others. In ethics, he is guilty if he only thinks of doing so."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2024;10M	Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel	<i>"Faith is of no avail in the absence of strength. Faith and strength, both are essential to accomplish any great work."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers

Year	Thinker / Source	Full Quote	Syllabus Topic
2024;10M	Swami Vivekananda	<i>"Learn everything that is good from others, but bring it in, and in your own way absorb it, do not become others."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2023;10M	Jawaharlal Nehru	<i>"To awaken the people, it is the women who must be awakened. Once she is on the move, the family moves, the village moves, the nation moves."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2023;10M	Mahatma Gandhi	<i>"The simplest acts of kindness are by far more powerful than a thousand heads bowing in prayer."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2023;10M	Swami Vivekananda	<i>"Do not hate anybody, because that hatred that comes out from you must, in the long run, come back to you. If you love, that love will come back to you, completing the circle."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2022;10M	APJ Abdul Kalam	<i>"If a country is to be corruption free and become a nation of beautiful minds, I strongly feel there are three key societal members who can make a difference. They are the father, the mother and the teacher."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2022;10M	Dalai Lama	<i>"Judge your success by what you had to give up in order to get it."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2022;10M	Potter Stewart	<i>"Ethics is knowing the difference between what you have the right to do and what is right to do."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2021;10M	Dalai Lama	<i>"We can never obtain peace in the outer world until and unless we obtain peace within ourselves."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2021;10M	Erik Erikson	<i>"Life doesn't make any sense without interdependence. We need each other, and the sooner we learn that, the better for us all."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2021;10M	Swami Vivekananda	<i>"Every work has got to pass through hundreds of difficulties before succeeding. Those that persevere will see the light, sooner or later."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers

Year	Thinker / Source	Full Quote	Syllabus Topic
2020;10M	Mahatma Gandhi	<i>"The best way to find yourself is to lose yourself in service of others."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2020;10M	Socrates	<i>"A system of morality which is based on relative emotional values is a mere illusion, a thoroughly vulgar conception which has nothing sound in it and nothing true."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2020;10M	Swami Vivekananda	<i>"Condemn none: if you can stretch out a helping hand do so. If not, fold your hands, bless your brothers and let them go their own way."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2019;10M	APJ Abdul Kalam	<i>"Where there is righteousness in the heart, there is beauty in the character. When there is beauty in the character, there is harmony in the home. When there is harmony in the home, there is order in the nation. When there is order in the nation, there is peace in the world."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2019;10M	Mahatma Gandhi	<i>"A man is but the product of his thoughts. What he thinks, he becomes."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2019;10M	Socrates	<i>"An unexamined life is not worth living."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2018;10M	Abraham Lincoln	<i>"The true rule, in determining to embrace, or reject anything, is not whether it has any evil in it; but whether it has more evil than good. There are few things wholly evil or wholly good. Almost everything, especially of governmental policy, is an inseparable compound of the two; so that our best judgment of the preponderance between them is continually demanded."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2018;10M	Mahatma Gandhi	<i>"Anger and intolerance are the enemies of correct understanding."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2018;10M	Thiruvalluvar	<i>"Falsehood takes the place of truth when it results in unblemished common good."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers

Year	Thinker / Source	Full Quote	Syllabus Topic
2017;10M	APJ Abdul Kalam	<i>"If a country is to be corruption free and become a nation of beautiful minds, I strongly feel there are three key societal members who can make a difference. They are the father, the mother and the teacher."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2015;10M	Mahatma Gandhi	<i>"The weak can never forgive; forgiveness is the attribute of the strong."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2013;10M	Abraham Lincoln	<i>"Nearly all men can withstand adversity, but if you want to test a man's character, give him power."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2013;10M	Aristotle	<i>"I count him braver who overcomes his desires than him who overcomes his enemies."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2013;10M	Mahatma Gandhi	<i>"There is enough on this earth for everyone's need but for no one's greed."</i>	Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers
2017;10M	Walter Lippmann	<i>"Without commonly shared and widely entrenched moral values and obligations, neither the law, nor democratic government, nor even the market economy will function properly."</i>	Ethics and Human Interface
2014;10M	Immanuel Kant	<i>"Human beings should always be treated as 'ends' in themselves and never as merely 'means'."</i>	Ethics and Human Interface
2013;10M	John Ruskin	<i>"The good of an individual is contained in the good of all."</i>	Ethics and Human Interface
2017;10M	Napoleon Bonaparte	<i>"Great ambition is the passion of a great character. Those endowed with it may perform very good or very bad acts. All depends on the principles which direct them."</i>	Human Values
2025;10M	Carl von Clausewitz	<i>"War is a diplomacy by other means."</i>	Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration

Year	Thinker / Source	Full Quote	Syllabus Topic
2024;10M	Eleanor Roosevelt	<i>"It is not enough to talk about peace, one must believe in it; and it is not enough to believe in it, one must act upon it."</i>	Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration
2020;10M	Hans Morgenthau	<i>"The will to power exists, but it can be tamed and be guided by rationality and principles of moral duty."</i>	Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration
2018;10M	UPSC Contextual	<i>"In doing a good thing, everything is permitted which is not prohibited expressly or by clear implication."</i>	Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration
2016;10M	Max Weber	<i>"It is not wise to apply to public administration the sort of moral and ethical norms we apply to matters of personal conscience. The State bureaucracy might possess its own independent bureaucratic morality."</i>	Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration

Summary Table: Key Administrative Maxims & Conceptual Statements (Topic-Wise)

Total administrative/conceptual statements compiled: **15**.

Year	Core Ethical Concept	Full Statement	Syllabus Topic
2021;10M	Integrity as Empowerment	<i>""Integrity is a value that empowers the human being.""</i>	Aptitude and Foundational Values
2025;10M	Administrative Decision-Making	<i>""For any kind of social re-engineering by successfully implementing welfare schemes, a civil servant must use reason and critical thinking in an ethical framework.""</i>	Attitude

Year	Core Ethical Concept	Full Statement	Syllabus Topic
2023;10M	EQ vs IQ (Daniel Goleman)	<i>""What really matters for success, character, happiness and lifelong achievements is a definite set of emotional skills – your EQ- not just purely cognitive abilities that are measured by conventional IQ tests.""</i>	Emotional Intelligence
2019;10M	Emotional Intelligence Concept	<i>""Emotional Intelligence is the ability to make your emotions work for you instead of against you.""</i>	Emotional Intelligence
2024;10M	Dimensions of Ethics	<i>""Ethics encompasses several key dimensions that are crucial in guiding individuals and organizations towards morally responsible behaviour.""</i>	Ethics and Human Interface
2024;10M	Ethical Relativism / Contextual Justice	<i>""The concept of Just and Unjust is contextual. What was just a year back, may turn out to be unjust in today's context. Changing context should be constantly under scrutiny to prevent miscarriage of justice.""</i>	Ethics and Human Interface
2017;10M	Inclusive Development / Consequences of Ethics	<i>""Increased national wealth did not result in equitable distribution of its benefits. It has created only some "enclaves of modernity and prosperity for a small minority at the cost of the majority.""</i>	Ethics and Human Interface
2023;10M	Crisis of Social Values	<i>""Corruption is the manifestation of the failure of core values in the society.""</i>	Human Values
2020;10M	Values in Education	<i>""Education is not an injunction, it is an effective and pervasive tool for all-round development of an individual and social transformation.""</i>	Human Values
2024;10M	Gender Equality & Probity	<i>""In Indian culture and value system, an equal opportunity has been provided irrespective of gender identity. The number of women in public service has been steadily increasing over the years.""</i>	Probity in Governance
2025;10M	Constitutional Morality (Ambedkar / George Grote)	<i>""Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment but a product of civil education and adherence of the rule of law.""</i>	Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration

Year	Core Ethical Concept	Full Statement	Syllabus Topic
2025;10M	Duty and Sense of Responsibility (Bhagavad Gita)	<i>“One who is devoted to one’s duty attains highest perfection in life.”</i>	Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration
2021;10M	Refugee Ethics (Non-Refoulement)	<i>“Refugees should not be turned back to the country where they would face prosecution or human rights violation.”</i>	Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration
2019;10M	Ethics in Public Service	<i>“Non-performance of duty by a public servant is a form of corruption.”</i>	Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration
2015;10M	Law vs Ethics	<i>“A mere compliance with law is not enough, the public servant also has to have a well-developed sensibility to ethical issues for effective discharge of duties.”</i>	Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration

Complete Details: Core Thinker & Philosopher Quotes by Topic

Aptitude and Foundational Values

“In looking for people to hire, you look for three qualities: integrity, intelligence and energy. And if they do not have the first, the other two will ruin you.”

— **Attributed to: Warren Buffett** (On prioritizing integrity in public and private recruitment)

- **UPSC Question:** In looking for people to hire, you look for three qualities: integrity, intelligence and energy. And if they do not have the first, the other two will ruin you. - Warren Buffett. What do you understand by this statement in the present-day scenario? Explain. (10 Marks - Year: 2018)
- **Microtheme:** Integrity X Intelligence X Energy

“Integrity without knowledge is weak and useless, but knowledge without integrity is dangerous and dreadful.”

— **Attributed to: Samuel Johnson** (*On combining intellect with moral character*)

- **UPSC Question:** Integrity without knowledge is weak and useless, but knowledge without integrity is dangerous and dreadful. What do you understand by this statement? Explain your stand with illustrations from the modern context. (10 Marks - Year: 2014)
- **Microtheme:** Integrity

Attitude

“Mindless addiction to Form, ignoring the Substance of the matter, results in rendering of injustice. A perceptive civil servant is one who ignores such literalness and carries out true intent.”

— **Attributed to: UPSC Contextual** (*On substance over form / spirit of the law vs. letter of the law*)

- **UPSC Question:** Mindless addiction to Form, ignoring the Substance of the matter, results in rendering of injustice. A perceptive civil servant is one who ignores such literalness and carries out true intent. Examine the above statement with suitable illustrations. (10 Marks - Year: 2024)
- **Microtheme:** Attitude for Civil Servants

“Hatred is destructive of a person’s wisdom and conscience that can poison a nation’s spirit.”

— **Attributed to: Dalai Lama** (*On negative emotions and social harmony*)

- **UPSC Question:** ‘Hatred is destructive of a person’s wisdom and conscience that can poison a nation’s spirit. Do you agree with this view? Justify your answer. (10 Marks - Year: 2020)
- **Microtheme:** Attitude for Individuals

Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers

“The strength of a society is not in its laws, but in the morality of its people.”

— **Attributed to: Swami Vivekananda** (*On moral character vs. legal regulation*)

- **UPSC Question:** “The strength of a society is not in its laws, but in the morality of its people.” – Swami Vivekananda (10 Marks - Year: 2025)
- **Microtheme:** Swami Vivekananda

“Those who in trouble untroubled are, Will trouble trouble itself.”

— **Attributed to: Thiruvalluvar** (*From Thirukkural / On resilience, equanimity, and fortitude*)

- **UPSC Question:** “Those who in trouble untroubled are, Will trouble trouble itself.” – Thiruvalluvar (10 Marks - Year: 2025)
- **Microtheme:** Tirukkural

“The greatest discovery of my generation is that a human being can alter his life by altering his attitudes.”

— **Attributed to: William James** (*Pragmatism / On the power of positive and moral attitude*)

- **UPSC Question:** “The greatest discovery of my generation is that a human being can alter his life by altering his attitudes.” – William James (10 Marks - Year: 2025)
- **Microtheme:** William James

“In law, a man is guilty when he violates the rights of others. In ethics, he is guilty if he only thinks of doing so.”

— **Attributed to: Immanuel Kant** (*Deontology / Moral purity of intent*)

- **UPSC Question:** “In law, a man is guilty when he violates the rights of others. In ethics, he is guilty if he only thinks of doing so.” — Immanuel Kant (10 Marks - Year: 2024)

- **Microtheme:** Immanuel Kant
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“Faith is of no avail in the absence of strength. Faith and strength, both are essential to accomplish any great work.”

— **Attributed to: Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel** (*On willpower, moral courage, and administrative resolution*)

- **UPSC Question:** “Faith is of no avail in the absence of strength. Faith and strength, both are essential to accomplish any great work.” — Sardar Patel (10 Marks - Year: 2024)
 - **Microtheme:** Sardar Patel
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“Learn everything that is good from others, but bring it in, and in your own way absorb it, do not become others.”

— **Attributed to: Swami Vivekananda** (*On cultural assimilation vs. blind imitation*)

- **UPSC Question:** “Learn everything that is good from others, but bring it in, and in your own way absorb it, do not become others.” — Swami Vivekananda (10 Marks - Year: 2024)
 - **Microtheme:** Swami Vivekananda
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“To awaken the people, it is the women who must be awakened. Once she is on the move, the family moves, the village moves, the nation moves.”

— **Attributed to: Jawaharlal Nehru** (*On gender equality and nation-building*)

- **UPSC Question:** “To awaken the people, it is the women who must be awakened. Once she is on the move, the family moves, the village moves, the nation moves.” – Jawaharlal Nehru (10 Marks - Year: 2023)
 - **Microtheme:** Jawaharlal Nehru
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“The simplest acts of kindness are by far more powerful than a thousand heads bowing in prayer.”

— **Attributed to: Mahatma Gandhi** (*On compassion and active altruism vs. mere ritualism*)

- **UPSC Question:** “The simplest acts of kindness are by far more powerful than a thousand heads bowing in prayer.” – Mahatma Gandhi (10 Marks - Year: 2023)
- **Microtheme:** Mahatma Gandhi

“Do not hate anybody, because that hatred that comes out from you must, in the long run, come back to you. If you love, that love will come back to you, completing the circle.”

— **Attributed to: Swami Vivekananda** (*On the moral law of cause and effect (Karma) and universal love*)

- **UPSC Question:** Do not hate anybody, because that hatred that comes out from you must, in the long run, come back to you. If you love, that love will come back to you, completing the circle.” – Swami Vivekanand. (10 Marks - Year: 2023)
- **Microtheme:** Swami Vivekananda

“If a country is to be corruption free and become a nation of beautiful minds, I strongly feel there are three key societal members who can make a difference. They are the father, the mother and the teacher.”

— **Attributed to: APJ Abdul Kalam** (*From 'Ignited Minds' / On value education*)

- **UPSC Question:** “If a country is to be corruption free and become a nation of beautiful minds, I strongly feel there are three key societal members who can make a difference. They are the father, the mother and the teacher.” – Abdul Kalam. (10 Marks - Year: 2022)
- **Microtheme:** A.P.J. Abdul Kalam

“Judge your success by what you had to give up in order to get it.”

— **Attributed to: Dalai Lama** (*On modern materialism vs. inner peace*)

- **UPSC Question:** "Judge your success by what you had to give up in order to get it." Dalai Lama. (10 Marks - Year: 2022)
 - **Microtheme:** Dalai Lama
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"Ethics is knowing the difference between what you have the right to do and what is right to do."

— **Attributed to: Potter Stewart** (*On legal rights vs. ethical responsibilities*)

- **UPSC Question:** Ethics is knowing the difference between what you have the right to do and what is right to do.' -Potter Stewart . (10 Marks - Year: 2022)
 - **Microtheme:** Potter Stewart
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"We can never obtain peace in the outer world until and unless we obtain peace within ourselves."

— **Attributed to: Dalai Lama** (*On inner peace as the foundation of global peace*)

- **UPSC Question:** "We can never obtain peace in the outer world until and unless we obtain peace within ourselves" (10 Marks - Year: 2021)
 - **Microtheme:** Dalai Lama
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"Life doesn't make any sense without interdependence. We need each other, and the sooner we learn that, the better for us all."

— **Attributed to: Erik Erikson** (*Developmental Psychology / On social cooperation*)

- **UPSC Question:** "Life doesn't make any sense without interdependence. We need each other, and the sooner we learn that it is better for us all" – Erik Erikson (10 Marks - Year: 2021)
 - **Microtheme:** Erik Erikson
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“Every work has got to pass through hundreds of difficulties before succeeding. Those that persevere will see the light, sooner or later.”

— **Attributed to: Swami Vivekananda** (*On perseverance, commitment, and work ethics*)

- **UPSC Question:** “Every work has got to pass through hundreds of difficulties before succeeding. Those that persevere will see the light, sooner or later” – Swami Vivekananda (10 Marks - Year: 2021)
- **Microtheme:** Swami Vivekananda

“The best way to find yourself is to lose yourself in service of others.”

— **Attributed to: Mahatma Gandhi** (*On selfless service (Seva) and self-realization*)

- **UPSC Question:** “The best way to find yourself is to lose yourself in service of others .” Mahatma Gandhi (10 Marks - Year: 2020)
- **Microtheme:** Mahatma Gandhi

“A system of morality which is based on relative emotional values is a mere illusion, a thoroughly vulgar conception which has nothing sound in it and nothing true.”

— **Attributed to: Socrates** (*On objective moral truth vs. ethical relativism*)

- **UPSC Question:** “A system of morality which is based on relative emotional values is a mere illusion, a thoroughly vulgar conception which has nothing sound in it and nothing true.” – Socrates. (10 Marks - Year: 2020)
- **Microtheme:** Socrates

“Condemn none: if you can stretch out a helping hand do so. If not, fold your hands, bless your brothers and let them go their own way.”

— **Attributed to: Swami Vivekananda** (*On empathy, non-judgmental attitude, and compassion*)

- **UPSC Question:** “Condemn none: if you can stretch out a helping hand do so. If not fold your hands, bless your brothers and let them go their own way.” – Swami Vivekanand (10 Marks - Year: 2020)

- **Microtheme:** Swami Vivekananda
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“Where there is righteousness in the heart, there is beauty in the character. When there is beauty in the character, there is harmony in the home. When there is harmony in the home, there is order in the nation. When there is order in the nation, there is peace in the world.”

— **Attributed to: APJ Abdul Kalam** (*Famous speech / On righteousness and global peace*)

- **UPSC Question:** “Where there is righteousness in the heart, there is beauty in the character. When there is beauty in the character, there is harmony in the home. When there is harmony in the home, there is order in the nation. When there is order in the nation, there is peace in the world.” (10 Marks - Year: 2019)
 - **Microtheme:** A.P.J. Abdul Kalam
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“A man is but the product of his thoughts. What he thinks, he becomes.”

— **Attributed to: Mahatma Gandhi** (*On the power of moral thoughts and attitude formation*)

- **UPSC Question:** “A man is but the product of his thoughts. What he thinks, he becomes.” – M.K.Gandhi (10 Marks - Year: 2019)
 - **Microtheme:** Mahatma Gandhi
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“An unexamined life is not worth living.”

— **Attributed to: Socrates** (*On self-reflection, critical inquiry, and virtue*)

- **UPSC Question:** “An unexamined life is not worth living.” – Socrates (10 Marks - Year: 2019)
 - **Microtheme:** Socrates
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“The true rule, in determining to embrace, or reject anything, is not whether it has any evil in it; but whether it has more evil than good. There are few things wholly evil or wholly good. Almost everything, especially of governmental policy, is an inseparable compound of the two; so that our best judgment of the preponderance between them is continually demanded.”

— **Attributed to: Abraham Lincoln** (*Speech on internal improvements, 1848 / On administrative pragmatism*)

- **UPSC Question:** The true rule, in determining to embrace, or reject any thing, is not whether it has any evil in it; but whether it has more evil than good. There are few things wholly evil or wholly good. Almost every thing, especially of governmental policy, is an in- separable compound of the two; so that our best judgement of the preponderance between them is continually demand. - Abraham Lincoln. (10 Marks - Year: 2018)
- **Microtheme:** Abraham Lincoln

“Anger and intolerance are the enemies of correct understanding.”

— **Attributed to: Mahatma Gandhi** (*On emotional self-regulation and rational discourse*)

- **UPSC Question:** Anger and intolerance are the enemies of correct understanding. — Mahatma Gandhi (10 Marks - Year: 2018)
- **Microtheme:** Mahatma Gandhi

“Falsehood takes the place of truth when it results in unblemished common good.”

— **Attributed to: Thiruvalluvar** (*From Thirukkural (Tirukkural) / On utilitarian truth and public welfare*)

- **UPSC Question:** Falsehood takes the place of truth when it results in unblemished common good. — Tirukkural (10 Marks - Year: 2018)
- **Microtheme:** Tirukkural

"If a country is to be corruption free and become a nation of beautiful minds, I strongly feel there are three key societal members who can make a difference. They are the father, the mother and the teacher."

— **Attributed to: APJ Abdul Kalam** (*Duplicate occurrence of the famous Ignited Minds quote*)

- **UPSC Question:** "If a country is to be corruption free and become a nation of beautiful minds, I strongly feel there are three key societal members who can make a difference. they are father, the mother and the teacher." – A. P. J. Abdul Kalam. Analyse. (10 Marks - Year: 2017)
- **Microtheme:** A.P.J. Abdul Kalam

"The weak can never forgive; forgiveness is the attribute of the strong."

— **Attributed to: Mahatma Gandhi** (*On moral strength, ahimsa (non-violence), and forgiveness*)

- **UPSC Question:** "The weak can never forgive; forgiveness is the attribute of the strong." (10 Marks - Year: 2015)
- **Microtheme:** Mahatma Gandhi

"Nearly all men can withstand adversity, but if you want to test a man's character, give him power."

— **Attributed to: Abraham Lincoln** (*On power, character, and governance*)

- **UPSC Question:** Nearly all men can withstand adversity, but if you want to test a man's character, give him power.—Abraham Lincoln (10 Marks - Year: 2013)
- **Microtheme:** Abraham Lincoln

"I count him braver who overcomes his desires than him who overcomes his enemies."

— **Attributed to: Aristotle** (*Classical Greek Philosophy / On self-control and virtue ethics*)

- **UPSC Question:** I count him braver who overcomes his desires than him who overcomes his ene- mies.— Aristotle (10 Marks - Year: 2013)

- **Microtheme:** Aristotle

“There is enough on this earth for everyone’s need but for no one’s greed.”

— **Attributed to: Mahatma Gandhi** (*On environmental sustainability, simplicity, and trusteeship*)

- **UPSC Question:** There is enough on this earth for every one’s need but for no one’s greed. Mahatma Gandhi. (10 Marks - Year: 2013)
- **Microtheme:** Mahatma Gandhi

Ethics and Human Interface

“Without commonly shared and widely entrenched moral values and obligations, neither the law, nor democratic government, nor even the market economy will function properly.”

— **Attributed to: Walter Lippmann** (*On social capital, moral consensus, and democratic governance*)

- **UPSC Question:** Without commonly shared and widely entrenched moral values and obligations, neither the law, nor democratic government, nor even the market economy will function properly. What do you understand by this statement? Explain with illustration in the contemporary times. (10 Marks - Year: 2017)
- **Microtheme:** Determinants of Ethics

“Human beings should always be treated as ‘ends’ in themselves and never as merely ‘means’.”

— **Attributed to: Immanuel Kant** (*Kantian Ethics / Categorical Imperative (Deontology)*)

- **UPSC Question:** Human beings should always be treated as ‘ends’ in themselves and never as merely ‘means’. Explain the meaning and significance of this statement, giving its implications in the modern techno-economic society. (10 Marks - Year: 2014)
- **Microtheme:** Normative Ethics (Deontology vs Teleology)

“The good of an individual is contained in the good of all.”

— **Attributed to: John Ruskin** (*From 'Unto This Last' / Concept of Sarvodaya (upliftment of all)*)

- **UPSC Question:** The good of an individual is contained in the good of all. What do you understand by this statement? How can this principle be implemented in public life? (10 Marks - Year: 2013)
- **Microtheme:** Ethics in Private and Public sphere

Human Values

“Great ambition is the passion of a great character. Those endowed with it may perform very good or very bad acts. All depends on the principles which direct them.”

— **Attributed to: Napoleon Bonaparte** (*On ambition, ethics, and leadership*)

- **UPSC Question:** “Great ambition is the passion of a great character. Those endowed with it may perform very good or very bad acts. All depends on the principles which direct them.” – Napoleon Bonaparte. Stating examples mention the rulers (i) who have harmed society and country, (ii) who worked for the development of society and country. (10 Marks - Year: 2017)
- **Microtheme:** Teachings of Great Leaders

Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration

“War is a diplomacy by other means.”

— **Attributed to: Carl von Clausewitz** (*On military ethics and political realism*)

- **UPSC Question:** Carl von Clausewitz once said, “War is a diplomacy by other means.” Critically analyse the above statement in the present context of contemporary geo-political conflict. (10 Marks - Year: 2025)
- **Microtheme:** Ethical Issues in International Relations and funding

“It is not enough to talk about peace, one must believe in it; and it is not enough to believe in it, one must act upon it.”

— **Attributed to: Eleanor Roosevelt** (*On active peace-building and human rights*)

- **UPSC Question:** “It is not enough to talk about peace, one must believe in it; and it is not enough to believe in it, one must act upon it” In the present context, the major weapon industries of the developed nations are adversely influencing continuation of number of wars for their own self-interest, all around the world. What are the ethical considerations of the powerful nations in today’s international arena to stop continuation of ongoing conflicts? (10 Marks - Year: 2024)
- **Microtheme:** Ethical Issues in International Relations and funding

“The will to power exists, but it can be tamed and be guided by rationality and principles of moral duty.”

— **Attributed to: Hans Morgenthau** (*Political realism vs. idealism in international relations*)

- **UPSC Question:** ‘The will to power exists, but it can be tamed and be guided by rationality and principles of moral duty.’ Examine this statement in the context of international relations. (10 Marks - Year: 2020)
- **Microtheme:** Ethical Issues in International Relations and funding

“In doing a good thing, everything is permitted which is not prohibited expressly or by clear implication.”

— **Attributed to: UPSC Contextual** (*On administrative discretion and positive action*)

- **UPSC Question:** In doing a good thing, everything is permitted which is not prohibited expressly or by clear implication. Examine the statement with suitable examples in the context of a public servant discharging his/her duties. (10 Marks - Year: 2018)
- **Microtheme:** Public/Civil Service Values

“It is not wise to apply to public administration the sort of moral and ethical norms we apply to matters of personal conscience. The State bureaucracy might possess its own independent bureaucratic morality.”

— **Attributed to: Max Weber** (*Administrative sociology / Ethics of responsibility vs. ethics of conviction*)

- **UPSC Question:** Max Weber said that it is not wise to apply to public administration the sort of moral and ethical norms we apply to matters of personal conscience. It is important to realise that the State bureaucracy might possess its own independent bureaucratic morality. Critically analyse this statement. (10 Marks - Year: 2016)
- **Microtheme:** Public/Civil Service Values

Complete Details: Key Administrative Maxims & Conceptual Statements by Topic

Aptitude and Foundational Values

“Integrity is a value that empowers the human being.”

— **Ethical Concept:** *Integrity as Empowerment*

- **UPSC Question:** “Integrity is a value that empowers the human being”. Justify with suitable illustration. (10 Marks - Year: 2021)
- **Microtheme:** Integrity

Attitude

“For any kind of social re-engineering by successfully implementing welfare schemes, a civil servant must use reason and critical thinking in an ethical framework.”

— **Ethical Concept:** *Administrative Decision-Making*

- **UPSC Question:** "For any kind of social re-engineering by successfully implementing welfare schemes, a civil servant must use reason and critical thinking in an ethical frame- work." Justify this statement with suitable examples. (10 Marks - Year: 2025)
- **Microtheme:** Social influence and persua- sion

Emotional Intelligence

""What really matters for success, character, happiness and lifelong achievements is a definite set of emotional skills – your EQ- not just purely cognitive abilities that are measured by conventional IQ tests.""

— **Ethical Concept:** EQ vs IQ (Daniel Goleman)

- **UPSC Question:** What really matters for success, character, happiness and lifelong achievements is a definite set of emotional skills – your EQ- not just purely cognitive abilities that are measured by conventional IQ tests." Do you agree with this view ? Give reasons in support of your answer. (10 Marks - Year: 2023)
- **Microtheme:** EQ vs IQ

""Emotional Intelligence is the ability to make your emotions work for you instead of against you.""

— **Ethical Concept:** Emotional Intelligence Concept

- **UPSC Question:** "Emotional Intelligence is the ability to make your emotions work for you instead of against you." Do you agree with this view? Discuss. (10 Marks - Year: 2019)
- **Microtheme:** EI: Concept and utility

Ethics and Human Interface

""Ethics encompasses several key dimensions that are crucial in guiding individuals and organizations towards morally responsible behaviour.""

— **Ethical Concept:** Dimensions of Ethics

- **UPSC Question:** "Ethics encompasses several key dimensions that are crucial in guiding individuals and organizations towards morally responsible behaviour." Explain the key dimensions of ethics that influence human actions. Discuss how these dimensions shape ethical decision-making in the professional context. (10 Marks - Year: 2024)
- **Microtheme:** Determinants of Ethics

""The concept of Just and Unjust is contextual. What was just a year back, may turn out to be unjust in today's context. Changing context should be constantly under scrutiny to prevent miscarriage of justice.""

— **Ethical Concept:** *Ethical Relativism / Contextual Justice*

- **UPSC Question:** "The concept of Just and Unjust is contextual. What was just a year back, may turn out to be unjust in today's context. Changing context should be constantly under scrutiny to prevent miscarriage of justice." Examine the above statement with suitable examples. (10 Marks - Year: 2024)
- **Microtheme:** Determinants of Ethics

"Increased national wealth did not result in equitable distribution of its benefits. It has created only some "enclaves of modernity and prosperity for a small minority at the cost of the majority.""

— **Ethical Concept:** *Inclusive Development / Consequences of Ethics*

- **UPSC Question:** Increased national wealth did not result in equitable distribution of its benefits. It has created only some "enclaves of modernity and prosperity for a small minority at the cost of the majority." Justify. (10 Marks - Year: 2017)
- **Microtheme:** Consequences of Ethics

Human Values

""Corruption is the manifestation of the failure of core values in the society.""

— **Ethical Concept:** *Crisis of Social Values*

- **UPSC Question:** "Corruption is the manifestation of the failure of core values in the society." In your opinion, what measures can be adopted to uplift the core values in the society? (10 Marks - Year: 2023)
- **Microtheme:** Crisis of Ethical Values

""Education is not an injunction, it is an effective and pervasive tool for all-round development of an individual and social transformation.""

— **Ethical Concept:** *Values in Education*

- **UPSC Question:** "Education is not an injunction, it is an effective and pervasive tool for all-round development of an individual and social transformation".Examine the New Education Policy,2020 (NEP,2020) in light of the above statement. (10 Marks - Year: 2020)
- **Microtheme:** Role of Educational institu- tions

Probity in Governance

""In Indian culture and value system, an equal opportunity has been provided irrespective of gender identity. The number of women in public service has been steadily increasing over the years.""

— **Ethical Concept:** *Gender Equality & Probity*

- **UPSC Question:** "In Indian culture and value system, an equal opportunity has been provided irrespective of gender identity. The number of women in public service has been steadily increasing over the years." Examine the gender specific challenges faced by female public servants and suggest to increase their efficiency in discharging their duties and maintaining high standards of probity. (10 Marks - Year: 2024)
- **Microtheme:** Probity in Governance

Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration

""Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment but a product of civil education and adherence of the rule of law.""

— **Ethical Concept:** *Constitutional Morality (Ambedkar / George Grote)*

- **UPSC Question:** "Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment but a product of civil education and adherence of the rule of law." Examine the significance of constitutional morality for public servant highlighting the role in promoting good governance and ensuring accountability in public administration. (10 Marks - Year: 2025)
- **Microtheme:** Accountability and Ethical Governance

""One who is devoted to one's duty attains highest perfection in life.""

— **Ethical Concept:** *Duty and Sense of Responsibility (Bhagavad Gita)*

- **UPSC Question:** "One who is devoted to one's duty attains highest perfection in life." Analyse this statement with reference to sense of responsibility and personal fulfilment as a civil servant. (10 Marks - Year: 2025)
- **Microtheme:** Public/Civil Service Values

""Refugees should not be turned back to the country where they would face prosecution or human rights violation.""

— **Ethical Concept:** *Refugee Ethics (Non-Refoulement)*

- **UPSC Question:** "Refugees should not be turned back to the country where they would face prosecution or human rights violation." Examine the statement with reference to the ethical dimension being violated by the nation claiming to be democratic with an open society. (10 Marks - Year: 2021)
- **Microtheme:** Ethical Issues in International Relations and funding

""Non-performance of duty by a public servant is a form of corruption.""

— **Ethical Concept:** *Ethics in Public Service*

- **UPSC Question:** "Non-performance of duty by a public servant is a form of corruption" Do you agree with this view? Justify your answer (150 words, 10m) (10 Marks - Year: 2019)
- **Microtheme:** Public/Civil Service Values

“A mere compliance with law is not enough, the public servant also has to have a well-developed sensibility to ethical issues for effective discharge of duties.”

— **Ethical Concept:** *Law vs Ethics*

- **UPSC Question:** A mere compliance with law is not enough, the public servant also has to have a well-developed sensibility to ethical issues for effective discharge of duties.” Do you agree? Explain with the help of two examples, where (i) an act is ethically right, but not legally and (ii) an act is legally right, but not ethically. (10 Marks - Year: 2015)
 - **Microtheme:** Laws, Rules, Regulations and Conscience as Ethical Guidance
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